

Spanish Tapas Bar

From sofrito to socarrat — the complete operations manual

44	\$44	23%	~\$28K
SEATS	AVG SPEND	FOOD COST	EST. MONTHLY NET

// WHAT A MICHELIN-TRAINED CHEF SEES IN SPANISH TAPAS

The Spanish kitchen operates on time in a way that no other European cuisine does. The sofrito takes 45 minutes minimum — not because the recipe says so, but because the tomato and onion need that long to lose their water, concentrate their sugars and develop the sweet, jammy base that defines Spanish flavour. Rush it and every dish built on it is compromised. The socarrat — the caramelised crust on the bottom of a proper paella — cannot be engineered. It happens in the last 3 minutes over maximum heat and you listen for the crackle. This guide teaches you to listen.

// WHAT THIS GUIDE DOES

The tapas format generates 30–40% higher average spends than single-plate dining. That is not an accident. It is the architecture of the format — small plates arrive in waves, each one creating the appetite for the next. The operator who understands this rhythm and trains their floor staff to manage it owns the most profitable casual dining model in Spanish food.

This guide is that training.

Menu Overview

Category	Item	Time	Food Cost
Tapas	Pan con Tomate — Catalan Tomato Bread	4 min	12%

Tapas	Jamón Ibérico — Bellota Dry-Cured Ham	3 min	21%
Tapas	Patatas Bravas — Fried Potatoes, Two Sauces	12 min	14%
Tapas	Gambas al Ajillo — Garlic Prawns in Sizzling Oil	6 min	19%
Tapas	Croquetas de Jamón — Ham Béchamel Croquettes	6 min	16%
Tapas	Tortilla Española — Spanish Omelette Wedge	5 min	13%
Mains	Paella Valenciana — Traditional Rice Dish	22 min	24%
Mains	Paella de Mariscos — Seafood Paella	22 min	26%
Mains	Cochinillo Asado — Slow Roast Suckling Pig	3hr + 8 min	22%
Mains	Pulpo a la Gallega — Galician Octopus	45 min + 5 min	20%
Mains	Chuletón — Grilled T-Bone Steak	15 min	25%
Mains	Bacalao al Pil Pil — Basque Salt Cod	20 min (48hr desalt)	21%
Mains	Pollo al Ajillo — Garlic Chicken	30 min	18%
Mains	Fideuà — Noodle Paella	18 min	22%
Mains	Rabo de Toro — Braised Oxtail	3.5hr + 8 min	19%
Mains	Menú del Día — Daily Set Menu	45 min table	24%
Desserts	Crema Catalana — Catalan Burnt Cream	2 min torch	11%
Desserts	Churros con Chocolate — Fried Dough + Hot Chocolate	8 min	14%
Desserts	Tarta de Santiago — Galician Almond Cake	3 min plating	13%
Desserts	Arroz con Leche — Spanish Rice Pudding	3 min plating	10%

Entrées / Tapas

Pan con Tomate — Catalan Tomato Bread

4 min | FC: 12% | Allergens: Gluten

- 1 Toast sourdough slices on a cast iron griddle until charred on both sides.
- 2 Rub immediately with a halved raw garlic clove while still hot.
- 3 Halve ripe tomatoes and rub vigorously over the bread — the flesh should dissolve in. Season with sea salt.
- 4 Drizzle generously with extra virgin olive oil. Serve immediately.

✂ The tomato must be room temperature — never cold. Cold tomato kills the flavour and the technique. This is the first thing a guest tastes. Make it count.

Jamón Ibérico — Bellota Dry-Cured Ham

3 min | FC: 21% | Allergens: None

- 1 Slice Jamón Ibérico de Bellota paper-thin using a sharp carving knife — never a machine.
- 2 Lay slices loosely on a warm plate — do not fold or stack.
- 3 Allow to reach room temperature before serving. Cold jamón loses its fat-bloom character.

✂ Bellota means acorn-fed. The fat melts at below body temperature — that silky finish on the palate is the entire point. Never refrigerate the serving plate.

Patatas Bravas — Fried Potatoes, Two Sauces

12 min | FC: 14% | Allergens: None

- 1 Par-boil diced Maris Piper potatoes until just tender (8 min). Drain and steam-dry 5 min.
- 2 Fry in sunflower oil at **180°C** until golden and crisp on all sides, approx 6 min.
- 3 Drain, season with sea salt and smoked paprika. Serve in a clay cazuela.
- 4 Drizzle brava sauce (spiced tomato) and alioli side by side — never mixed.

✂ The double-cook is non-negotiable. Par-boiling first gives a fluffy interior; high-heat frying gives the crust. One step alone gives you neither.

Entrées / Tapas (continued)

Gambas al Ajillo — Garlic Prawns in Sizzling Oil

6 min | FC: 19% | Allergens: Shellfish

- 1 Heat a terracotta cazuela directly on a high flame until smoking.
- 2 Add generous olive oil, thinly sliced garlic and a dried guindilla chilli. Let garlic turn golden — 60 seconds.
- 3 Add shell-on king prawns, season with sea salt. Cook 2 min per side until pink and just cooked through.
- 4 Finish with a splash of dry sherry. Serve immediately in the same cazuela — it should still be sizzling at the table.

✂ The dish must arrive sizzling. If it stops at the pass, it's dead. This is theatre as much as food — the sound sells the next order.

Croquetas de Jamón — Ham Béchamel Croquettes

6 min | FC: 16% | Allergens: Gluten, Dairy, Eggs

- 1 Prepare béchamel with butter, flour, warm milk and finely diced jamón ibérico. Cook until very thick. Season, chill overnight.
- 2 Shape into oval croquettes. Coat in flour, egg wash, then fine breadcrumbs. Freeze 30 min before service.
- 3 Fry from frozen at **180°C** for 4–5 min until deep golden. Drain on paper.
- 4 Serve immediately — the molten centre is the entire experience.

⚡ Croquetas must be made with proper jamón in the béchamel — not as a garnish. The fat from the jamón enriches the entire sauce. Inferior ham = inferior croqueta.

Tortilla Española — Spanish Omelette Wedge

5 min | FC: 13% | Allergens: Eggs

- 1 Confite thin-sliced onion and potato in olive oil at **140°C** for 20–25 min until completely soft. Drain oil.
- 2 Beat eggs, season well. Fold in warm potato-onion mix. Rest 5 min.
- 3 Cook in a 22cm non-stick pan on medium heat 4 min. Flip with a plate. Cook reverse side 2 min — centre should remain custardy.
- 4 Rest 10 min before cutting into wedges. Serve warm or room temperature.

⚡ A tortilla is not a frittata. The inside should be barely set — trembling, almost runny. Fully cooked is overcooked. This is the debate that defines Spanish cooking.

Mains

Paella Valenciana — Traditional Rice Dish

22 min | FC: 24% | Allergens: Gluten possible

- 1 Heat paella pan over high heat. Brown chicken thighs and rabbit pieces in olive oil. Remove, rest.
- 2 Add sofrito (pre-made, 45 min minimum). Add green beans and flat beans. Stir 2 min.
- 3 Add Bomba rice, stir to coat in sofrito. Add hot chicken stock — ratio 1:2.5 rice to liquid. Add saffron.
- 4 Return meat. Cook 18 min without stirring. Last 3 min: maximum heat for socarrat.
- 5 Remove from heat. Rest 5 min covered with foil. Serve from pan.

⚡ The socarrat is the caramelised crust on the bottom. Listen for a dry crackling sound — that's it forming. Remove immediately after. This cannot be rushed or engineered — only heard.

Paella de Mariscos — Seafood Paella

22 min | FC: 26% | Allergens: Shellfish

- 1 Sauté squid rings in hot olive oil 2 min. Add sofrito and pimentón. Cook 2 min.
- 2 Add Bomba rice. Add hot fish/shellfish stock with saffron — ratio 1:2.5.
- 3 Cook 15 min. Arrange prawns, mussels and clams on top. Cook 4 more min until shellfish open.
- 4 Maximum heat 2–3 min for socarrat. Rest 4 min, serve from pan.

✂ The highest food cost main at 26%. Justify it with quality shellfish and a properly made fish stock. Frozen shellfish signals itself immediately on the palate.

Cochinillo Asado — Slow Roast Suckling Pig

3hr roast + 8 min | FC: 22%

- 1 Rub cochinillo (3–4kg) with lard, sea salt and garlic. Place skin-side up in a deep roasting tray with water.
- 2 Roast at 160°C for 2.5–3hrs until flesh pulls from bone. Baste every 45 min.
- 3 Final 15 min: raise to 220°C for crackling. Rest 10 min before service.
- 4 Portion to order using a ceramic plate (the Segovian tradition — prove it's tender).

✂ In Segovia they cut cochinillo with a plate to prove how tender it is, then smash the plate. The ritual is the dish. Your staff should know this story and tell it.

Mains (continued)

Pulpo a la Gallega — Galician Octopus

45 min boil + 5 min | FC: 20%

- 1 Freeze octopus 48hrs before cooking (breaks down muscle fibre). Defrost fully.
- 2 "Scare" the octopus — dip in boiling water 3 times before full submersion. This firms the skin.
- 3 Boil 40–45 min until a skewer passes through the thickest tentacle with slight resistance. Rest in liquid.
- 4 Slice tentacles, arrange on wooden board. Dress with olive oil, smoked paprika (pimentón de la Vera), sea salt flakes.

✂ Galicians serve pulpo on a wooden board with sea salt and pimentón. No garnish. No fuss. The dish is the technique. Overcook by 5 min and you have rubber.

Rabo de Toro — Braised Oxtail

3.5hr braise + 8 min | FC: 19%

- 1 Season and brown oxtail pieces on all sides in a heavy casserole. Remove. (Start 08:30 per prep schedule.)
- 2 Sauté mirepoix in the same fat until caramelised. Add tomato paste, cook 3 min.
- 3 Deglaze with Pedro Ximénez sherry. Return oxtail. Add beef stock to cover. Braise at **160°C** for 3.5hrs.
- 4 Strain sauce and reduce by half. Pick meat from bone, portion. To order: heat in sauce 8 min. Serve with mashed potato.

✂ Pedro Ximénez is the magic. A sweet, syrupy sherry that gives the braise its dark, raisined depth. Substitute with regular red wine and you lose 30% of the character.

Bacalao al Pil Pil — Basque Salt Cod

20 min + 48hr desalt | FC: 21%

- 1 Desalt cod 48hrs in cold water, changing water every 12hrs. Dry thoroughly before service.
- 2 Confite cod skin-side up in olive oil at **60°C** for 15 min until just cooked. Remove cod, reserve oil.
- 3 Swirl the warm oil in the pan — the gelatine from the cod skin creates the emulsion naturally. This is pil pil.
- 4 Return cod to sauce. Serve with the sauce coating the fish. Garnish with piquillo pepper.

✂ Pil pil is one of the great chef tests. The emulsion forms from nothing but fish gelatine and olive oil. No cream, no butter. It takes patience and a gentle wrist.

Mains (continued)

Pollo al Ajillo — Garlic Chicken

30 min | FC: 18%

- 1 Joint whole chicken into 8 pieces. Season generously with salt and pimentón.
- 2 Brown in olive oil over high heat — skin side down first, 6 min. Flip 4 min. Remove.
- 3 Add 10–12 whole garlic cloves (skin on) to same pan. Cook 2 min. Add dry sherry, let it reduce by half.
- 4 Return chicken. Cover, cook 18 min at **180°C** until cooked through. Finish with fresh parsley.

✂ Whole garlic cloves soften to sweet, spreadable paste during cooking. The guest who discovers this mid-dish always orders it again.

Fideuà — Noodle Paella

18 min | FC: 22%

- 1 Toast thin fideuà noodles (No. 2) dry in the paella pan until golden — 3 min. Remove.
- 2 Sauté squid, prawns in sofrito in the same pan. Add toasted noodles back.
- 3 Add hot fish stock (ratio 1:2 noodles to stock). Cook 12 min until absorbed and noodles stand upright.
- 4 Crisp under grill 2 min. Serve with alioli on the side — essential.

✂ Fideuà is the Valencian coast answer to paella. The toasted noodle technique is identical in principle to socarrat — concentrated, slightly smoky, deeply satisfying.

Desserts

Crema Catalana — Catalan Burnt Cream

2 min torch finish | FC: 11%

- 1 Infuse cream with lemon zest, cinnamon stick and orange zest. Bring to simmer. Cool.
- 2 Whisk egg yolks with sugar. Temper warm cream in. Pour into shallow terracotta dishes.
- 3 Bake in bain-marie at 150°C for 30 min until just set with a wobble. Chill thoroughly.
- 4 To order: dust with caster sugar. Torch in even circular motion until amber caramel forms. Serve immediately.

✂ Crema catalana pre-dates crème brûlée by at least a century — a point worth making to guests. The citrus and cinnamon infusion is the differentiator. Never skip it.

Desserts (continued)

Churros con Chocolate — Fried Dough with Hot Chocolate

8 min | FC: 14% | Allergens: Gluten

- 1 Make choux-style dough: water, flour, salt, pinch of sugar. Pipe into 15cm lengths.
- 2 Fry in sunflower oil at 180°C for 3–4 min until golden and crisp. Drain.
- 3 Roll in cinnamon sugar immediately. Serve upright in a tall glass or cup.
- 4 Chocolate: melt Valrhona 70% with warm cream and milk. Serve hot in a small jug alongside.

✂ Churros are fried to order — 8 minutes. The server must pre-sell this at the start of the meal, not when clearing mains. Cold churros in cold chocolate is a waste of a dish.

Tarta de Santiago — Galician Almond Cake

3 min plating | FC: 13% | Allergens: Nuts (almonds), Eggs

- 1 Bake in advance: ground almonds, sugar, eggs, lemon zest, cinnamon. No flour — naturally gluten-free base.
- 2 Cool completely. Dust icing sugar through the Cross of St James stencil over the top.
- 3 To order: slice and plate with a quenelle of orange mascarpone.

✂ The cross of Santiago on every tarta is the mark of Galicia. Use the stencil every time. That small gesture connects the dish to 700 years of pilgrimage culture.

Arroz con Leche — Spanish Rice Pudding

3 min plating | FC: 10%

- 1 Simmer short-grain rice in whole milk with lemon peel, cinnamon stick and sugar for 35 min, stirring constantly.
- 2 Remove lemon and cinnamon. Cool to room temperature. Chill.
- 3 To order: scoop into clay bowl. Dust generously with cinnamon. Serve chilled.

✂ Best food cost on the menu at 10%. Never undersell it. A properly made arroz con leche — creamy, faintly bitter from cinnamon — is a better dessert than many restaurant cheesecakes.

Drinks

Sangria — Red Wine Punch (Jug, serves 2) \$22.00
Tinto de Verano — Red Wine & Lemon Soda \$9.00
Estrella Damm — Spanish Lager 330ml \$8.00
Cava — Spanish Sparkling Glass 150ml \$12.00
Rioja Tempranillo — Glass 150ml \$11.00

Horchata de Chufa — Tiger Nut Milk

\$7.00

Café Cortado — Espresso + Warm Milk

\$5.00

Rebujito — Sherry & Lemonade

\$10.00

Service Scripts

These are not suggestions. These are the words your floor staff say. Verbatim, every time, until they own them.

01 — WELCOME + SANGRIA UPSELL

"The sangria is made in-house — red wine, brandy, orange, cinnamon. Jug serves two. \$22. Better value than two glasses of wine and it's the way the Spanish drink it."

02 — TAPAS ARRIVAL FLOW

"We bring things as they're ready — that's the tapas rhythm. Don't wait for everything before eating. Start with the pan con tomate while it's warm."

03 — PAELLA EXPLANATION + SOCARRAT

"The paella takes 22 minutes because the rice has to crust on the bottom — that's the socarrat. It's the best part. If your paella arrives in 10 minutes, it's not paella."

04 — CHURROS PRE-SELL

"The churros are fried to order. 8 minutes. Worth planning for. The chocolate is real — Valrhona, served hot. It's a proper dessert, not an afterthought."

05 — RETURN VISIT + MENÚ DEL DÍA

"Lunch Tuesday to Friday we do Menú del Día — starter, main, dessert, glass of wine, \$28. That's how the Spanish eat lunch. Worth coming back for."

✂ Script delivery is not robotic recitation. It's confident, conversational, knowledgeable. The server who delivers script 03 correctly is teaching the guest about Spanish culture. That's the job.

Daily Prep Schedule

Time	Task	Notes
07:00	Sofrito — begin	45 min minimum. Non-negotiable. Base of everything.
08:30	Oxtail into braise	3.5hr braise. Must be on by 08:30 for service readiness.
09:00	Tortilla Española bake	Bake, cool, hold at room temp. Cut to order.
10:00	Pulpo boil	45 min boil. Scare technique applied first.
11:00	Cochinillo into oven	3hr roast. 160°C to start, blast at end.
12:00	Lunch service opens	Menú del Día available Tue–Fri.
15:00	Reset + team brief	Stock counts. Mise en place for dinner.
17:00	Paella stock prep	Chicken and fish stock for dinner paellas.
18:30	Dinner service opens	Full menu available.
22:30	Close	Kitchen close, cleanup, oxtail into fridge.

P&L Summary

Metric	Amount
Daily Revenue	~\$3,520
Weekly Revenue	~\$21,120
Monthly Revenue	~\$91,520
Food Cost (23%)	~\$21,050
Labour (30%)	~\$27,456
Overheads (16%)	~\$14,643
Net Profit (~31%)	~\$28,371 / month

Allergen Register

Always verify allergens with kitchen before service. This register is a guide — not a guarantee. Allergen cross-contamination risk must be assessed per order.

Dish	Allergens

Pan con Tomate	Gluten
Jamón Ibérico	None declared
Croquetas de Jamón	Gluten Dairy Eggs
Gambas al Ajillo	Shellfish
Tortilla Española	Eggs
Paella Valenciana	Gluten (possible)
Paella de Mariscos	Shellfish
Tarta de Santiago	Nuts (almonds) Eggs
Churros con Chocolate	Gluten